Mrs. Riberio and What Teachers Make

By Sarah Kay and Taylor Mali

Mrs. Riberio

I was in Northern India, at a school run entirely by women volunteers, when I heard it for the first time in ages. It was barely audible above the shouting of children -- the squeals and laughter bubbling from the schoolyard into the classroom windows. But it was there: the swish of silk saris and the jingle jangle of bangles on thin wrists like wind chimes.

This is what learning sounds like. I remember.

INTRODUCTION

One of my favorite quotes about teaching goes something like this: One hundred years from now it will not matter what kind of car I drove, what kind of house I lived in, how much money I had in the bank, nor what my clothes looked like. But the world may be a little better, because... I was important in the life of a child. Teachers, I believe, are the most important people in our society – they shape the future.

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In her poem Mrs. Riberio, author Sarah Kay pays tribute to a teacher who most definitely shaped her future and the future of a multitude of students. Mrs. Riberio by Sarah Kay.

I remember when I was five years old, the principal of my Junior School was Mrs. Ribeiro. She was an Indian woman the size of a nightlight, and she glided like a sailboat through the hallways of our school.

Once, when I got close enough to grab a fistful of her draping
silk sari, I lifted it to try and see whether she had any feet at all.
I thought she floated.

We begged to be sent to her office: the hanging plants like a jungle
above our heads, her quiet laughter. Adults needed appointments,
but we did not. And even when she was in a grown-up meeting,

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all it took was a gentle knock on the door, a peek around the corner,
and she was off calling, "Sorry dear. We'll have to reschedule.
I have to see someone else about a very important matter.
It's about a gold star. It's about a new diorama. It's about a finished reading book one level higher than last time."

She visited every classroom, knew every student by name. She spoke to us like we were scholars. Artists. Scientists. Athletes.
Musicians. And we were My world was the size of a crayon box,
and it took every color to draw her.

Once, on a New York City sidewalk, a group of women in a brightly colored saris walked by and someone shouted, "Look, Mom. Look at all those principals!" My world was the size of a classroom. It was a tall as I could stretch

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my fingers, calling, Please! Let me be the one to read to Mrs. Ribeiro. Let me be the one to show her what I know.
Clothes.
Shirt. Pants. Socks. Shoes.
Animals.
Cat. Dog. Bird. Fish.
Look how much I know.

She brought us guests and artists and a petting zoo. They set up the cages in the parking lot while we were still tucked up in our classroom, unaware. Rabbits and guinea pigs poked out their noses, but Mrs. Ribeiro came to rest in front of the llama cage.

She and the llama considered each other for a long time. She asked if he was tame enough to go inside. The trainers laughed and told her he was plenty tame, but he didn't know how to go up stairs. So she led him to the elevator. And when the doors slid open on the second floor, there stood Mrs. Ribeiro in her bright pink sari,

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with gold bangles and a llama on a leash.

She floated from class to class, and we stared, cheered, laughed, and shouted. We tugged at her sari calling, "Miss, what is that? Where did it come from?" She made us wonder. She made us question. She made us proud of what we had learned.
Clothes.
Shirt. Pants. Shoes. Socks. Saris.
Animals.
Cat. Dog. Bird. Fish. Llama.
Look how much I've learned.

She taught us to share. She taught us to listen when someone else is speaking. And then she let us go. We were dandelion seeds released to the wind, she asked for no return. We are saplings now with gentle hands.

The girl with bright cheeks and messy hairpins now works at an orphanage in Cameroon. The boy with the color-ordered markers is now a graphic designer in

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Chicago. The one with the best diorama is now an animal activist in Argentina. The girl who loved to read out loud is now a poet in India. She let us fly.
So I find myself at the front of a classroom. My students tug at my sleeves and ask me, "Miss, do all poets wear big black boots?" I pray for patience. For wisdom. To find a way to tame all the peculiar animals of this world, to coax them enough to brave the elevator, to see the doors slide open to my student's gaping mouths.

All the wile they wonder.
They worry about everything.
They worry about what to write.
They worry about their grades.
They talk over one another until I cannot hear them.

I tell them, "Listen. Listen to one another like you know you are scholars. Artists. Scientists. Athletes. Musicians. Like you know you will be the ones to shape this world. Show me how many colors you know how to

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draw with.

Show me how proud you are of what you have learned.

And I promise I will do the same."

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sarah Kay
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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

TRANSITION

So . . . . Sarah Kay leaves us with a teacher's promise . . . but in this next poem, Taylor Mali leaves us with just as much passion when he speaks the truth about teaching. After all, he does have a policy about honest and ass-kicking. What Teachers Make by Taylor Mali

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What Teachers Make

He says the problem with teachers is

What's a kid going to learn

from someone who decided his best option in life

was to become a teacher?

He reminds the other dinner guests that it's true

what they say about teachers:

Those who can, do; those who can't, teach.

I decide to bite my tongue instead of his

and resist the temptation to remind the dinner guests

that it's also true what they say about lawyers.

Because we're eating, after all, and this is polite

conversation.

I mean, you're a teacher, Taylor.

Be honest. What do you make?

And I wish he hadn't done that— asked me to be

honest—

because, you see, I have this policy about honesty and

ass--kicking:

if you ask for it, then I have to let you have it.

You want to know what I make?
I make kids work harder than they ever thought they could.
I can make a C+ feel like a Congressional Medal of Honor and an A-- feel like a slap in the face.
How dare you waste my time
with anything less than your very best.
I make kids sit through 40 minutes of study hall
in absolute silence. *No, you may not work in groups.*
No, you may not ask a question.
Why won't I let you go to the bathroom?
Because you're bored.
And you don't really have to go to the bathroom, do you?
I make parents tremble in fear when I call home:
Hi. This is Mr. Mali. I hope I haven't called at a bad time,
I just wanted to talk to you about something your son said today.
To the biggest bully in the grade, he said,
"Leave the kid alone. I still cry sometimes, don't you?
It's no big deal."

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And that was noblest act of courage I have ever seen.
I make parents see their children for who they are and what they can be.
You want to know what I make? I make kids wonder,
I make them question.
I make them criticize.
I make them apologize and mean it.
I make them write.
I make them read, read, read.
I make them spell *definitely beautiful, definitely beautiful, definitely beautiful*
over and over and over again until they will never misspell
either one of those words again.
I make them show all their work in math
and hide it on their final drafts in English.
I make them understand that if you've got *this*,
then you follow *this*,
and if someone ever tries to judge you
by what you make, you give them *this*.

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Here, let me break it down for you, so you know what I say is true:

Teachers make a goddamn difference! Now what about you?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
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